has recommended scrapping the SI exams. The government has now set up a ministerial committee to look into the matter, but Meena has found it a good occasion to extract the moral edge by demanding quick action.

Meena has also raised serious allegations of corruption in the Information Technology department. His claims have led to a Rajasthan High Court order for the Anti-Corruption Bureau to probe every tender issued in the past five years. More recently, Meena says, he informed Sharma about several individuals without MBBS degrees alleg-

THE STALEMATE

- **Kirodi Lal Meena, who resigned from cabinet in June, continues to push the Sharma regime to act swiftly on corruption–older as well as ongoing cases**
- **Sharma has not accepted the veteran leader's resignation so far, as his presence is crucial to win tribal seats in the upcoming bypolls**

edly being registered as doctors by the Rajasthan Medical Council. The government has since suspended the council registrar and set up an inquiry panel.

Sharma, on his part, has maintained that he values Meena's presence in the cabinet. However, the delay in addressing his resignation suggests a strategy to wear Meena out. The BJP is facing seven crucial assembly bypolls by December, including in Dausa and Deoli Unniyara in the Meena tribal belt of east Rajasthan and Salumber and Chaurasi in the southern tribal belt. Accepting Meena's resignation could hurt the BJP's chances in these areas, where the party lost all but one seat in the previous assembly election. But given Meena's impulsive nature, he is likely to remain a thorn in the party's side. That's a dilemma the Sharma regime will have to live with. ■

Workation Bug

Holiday cards as wedding, birthday gifts; 'staycations' and 'even workations'...it seems there's no stopping the Indian traveller as he sets out to satisfy his wanderlust. India's travel and tourism figures are set to see a full recovery and even surpass pre-pandemic peaks this year, says the industry. 'People are searching for ideas and stays that provide an emotional connection with cultures and nature, offering an authentic encounter with the destination. Searches for homestays and villas witnessed a growth of 24 per cent in 2023 over the previous year,' says the annual tourism trends report of online travel marketplace MakeMyTrip. "The supply side in the industry has fully recovered while the demand side is on growth mode," says Rajesh Magaow, co-founder and Group CEO. "Somehow, the post-Covid boom of pent-up demand or 'revenge travel' has become permanent."

By Avishek G. Dastidar



Photographs: SHUTTERSTOCK

WEEKEND GETAWAYS

Destinations within 300 km of a source city saw the highest growth in 2023. **Jim Corbett National Park** in Uttarakhand led the charge, with **131%** growth in online searches, followed by Ooty (Tamil Nadu) and Munnar (Kerala) in the south

FLY ME TO THE...

Tier-2 cities emerged as the highest growth destinations in domestic flights category, thanks to the government's UDAN scheme. Lucknow, **Thiruvananthapuram**, Bhubaneswar and Indore led in online searches. Delhi-NCR and Goa topped among the 'metros'



152 MN

No. of **domestic air carrier passengers** in 2023, its best-ever year (9% growth y-on-y)

20 MN

Avg. no. of passengers ferried daily by **Indian Railways** this fiscal, up from 18.4 mn in 2023-24